EFSP Auxiliary ESL Curriculum

Environmental Consulting English

Instructor guide for advanced ESL learners working in environmental consulting

Audience: environmental consultants, remediation managers, sustainability analysts, field scientists, permitting specialists, ESG teams, and environmental project managers

Focus: An environmental consulting English curriculum for site assessments, permitting, remediation, sampling, stakeholder meetings, sustainability reporting, compliance, and client-risk communication.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Purpose and Course Logic

An environmental consulting English curriculum for site assessments, permitting, remediation, sampling, stakeholder meetings, sustainability reporting, compliance, and client-risk communication.

Core language challenge

Advanced learners do not only need vocabulary. They need the ability to ask which standard applies, who owns the decision, what evidence is sufficient, what risk is being accepted, and how to disagree without sounding vague, defensive, or reckless.

Each module trains a realistic workplace pressure point with role-specific terms, decision language, pushback practice, and a written output learners can adapt to their own work.

Course objectives

- Use environmental consulting terminology accurately in meetings, written updates, handoffs, escalations, reviews, and client or stakeholder conversations.
- Turn vague requests into specific questions about evidence, owner, deadline, constraint, risk, and decision rights.
- Push back on unsafe, unsupported, noncompliant, unrealistic, or poorly scoped proposals while preserving professional trust.
- Handle realistic dialogues from the field, including conflict, uncertainty, documentation gaps, customer or stakeholder pressure, and cross-functional disagreement.
- Produce concise workplace outputs: briefing notes, escalation updates, meeting scripts, risk memos, decision records, and follow-up messages.

Instructor Module Plans

Module 1. Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments (90 minutes)

Explain environmental risk before conclusions are final.

Learners should be able to

- Use these terms accurately: Phase I ESA, REC, Phase II, due diligence.
- Explain the workplace tension: Recognized environmental conditions, sampling scope, limitations, and due diligence matter.
- Respond professionally when a stakeholder says: Say no issues were found.
- Draft a usable site-assessment caveat with facts, caveats, owner, and next step.

Customized scenario

Workplace pressure

A buyer wants assurance that a site is clean.

Say no issues were found.

Recognized environmental conditions, sampling scope, limitations, and due diligence matter.

Classroom sequence

1. Terminology drill: define each term, then use it in one sentence from the learner's own role.
2. Risk map: identify the stakeholder, the decision, the evidence gap, the operating constraint, and the cost of being wrong.
3. Pushback ladder: move from clarifying question to evidence-based objection to consequence to decision request.

4. Output lab: draft and revise a site-assessment caveat.

Module 2. Sampling Plans and Data Quality (90 minutes)

Discuss field data with chain-of-custody and QA language.

Learners should be able to

- Use these terms accurately: sampling plan, chain of custody, detection limit, QA/QC.
- Explain the workplace tension: Decision units, detection limits, QA/QC, and regulatory standards must support conclusions.
- Respond professionally when a stakeholder says: Reduce sampling to save budget.
- Draft a usable sampling-plan explanation with facts, caveats, owner, and next step.

Customized scenario

Workplace pressure

A client questions why more samples are needed.

Reduce sampling to save budget.

Decision units, detection limits, QA/QC, and regulatory standards must support conclusions.

Classroom sequence

1. Terminology drill: define each term, then use it in one sentence from the learner's own role.
2. Risk map: identify the stakeholder, the decision, the evidence gap, the operating constraint, and the cost of being wrong.
3. Pushback ladder: move from clarifying question to evidence-based objection to consequence to decision request.
4. Output lab: draft and revise a sampling-plan explanation.

Module 3. Permitting and Agency Coordination (90 minutes)

Manage agency questions without promising outcomes.

Learners should be able to

- Use these terms accurately: permit, agency comment, public notice, modeling.
- Explain the workplace tension: Agency discretion, technical support, timelines, and public comments may affect approval.
- Respond professionally when a stakeholder says: Tell the client approval is still certain.
- Draft a usable permit-response update with facts, caveats, owner, and next step.

Customized scenario

Workplace pressure

A permit reviewer requests additional modeling.

Tell the client approval is still certain.

Agency discretion, technical support, timelines, and public comments may affect approval.

Classroom sequence

1. Terminology drill: define each term, then use it in one sentence from the learner's own role.
2. Risk map: identify the stakeholder, the decision, the evidence gap, the operating constraint, and the cost of being wrong.

3. Pushback ladder: move from clarifying question to evidence-based objection to consequence to decision request.
4. Output lab: draft and revise a permit-response update.

Module 4. Remediation Options and Risk (90 minutes)

Compare cleanup options in plain language.

Learners should be able to

- Use these terms accurately: remediation, exposure pathway, cap, long-term monitoring.
- Explain the workplace tension: Exposure pathway, remedy effectiveness, operations disruption, cost, and long-term monitoring matter.
- Respond professionally when a stakeholder says: Excavate immediately.
- Draft a usable remediation options memo with facts, caveats, owner, and next step.

Customized scenario

Workplace pressure

A site has contaminated soil under an active facility.

Excavate immediately.

Exposure pathway, remedy effectiveness, operations disruption, cost, and long-term monitoring matter.

Classroom sequence

1. Terminology drill: define each term, then use it in one sentence from the learner's own role.
2. Risk map: identify the stakeholder, the decision, the evidence gap, the operating constraint, and the cost of being wrong.
3. Pushback ladder: move from clarifying question to evidence-based objection to consequence to decision request.
4. Output lab: draft and revise a remediation options memo.

Module 5. Regulatory Compliance and Audits (90 minutes)

Explain findings without exaggeration or minimization.

Learners should be able to

- Use these terms accurately: compliance audit, corrective action, recordkeeping, inspection.
- Explain the workplace tension: Compliance obligations, corrective action, documentation, and recurrence risk need review.
- Respond professionally when a stakeholder says: Call them minor housekeeping items.
- Draft a usable compliance finding summary with facts, caveats, owner, and next step.

Customized scenario

Workplace pressure

An audit finds storage and labeling issues.

Call them minor housekeeping items.

Compliance obligations, corrective action, documentation, and recurrence risk need review.

Classroom sequence

1. Terminology drill: define each term, then use it in one sentence from the learner's own role.

2. Risk map: identify the stakeholder, the decision, the evidence gap, the operating constraint, and the cost of being wrong.
3. Pushback ladder: move from clarifying question to evidence-based objection to consequence to decision request.
4. Output lab: draft and revise a compliance finding summary.

Module 6. Sustainability and ESG Reporting (90 minutes)

Use sustainability claims carefully.

Learners should be able to

- Use these terms accurately: ESG, Scope 1, Scope 2, Scope 3, carbon neutral.
- Explain the workplace tension: Scope, boundary, methodology, assurance, and claim substantiation are required.
- Respond professionally when a stakeholder says: Use the claim because offsets were purchased.
- Draft a usable sustainability claim review with facts, caveats, owner, and next step.

Customized scenario

Workplace pressure

Marketing wants to claim the company is carbon neutral.

Use the claim because offsets were purchased.

Scope, boundary, methodology, assurance, and claim substantiation are required.

Classroom sequence

1. Terminology drill: define each term, then use it in one sentence from the learner's own role.
2. Risk map: identify the stakeholder, the decision, the evidence gap, the operating constraint, and the cost of being wrong.
3. Pushback ladder: move from clarifying question to evidence-based objection to consequence to decision request.
4. Output lab: draft and revise a sustainability claim review.

Module 7. Community and Stakeholder Meetings (90 minutes)

Communicate technical risk to nontechnical audiences.

Learners should be able to

- Use these terms accurately: stakeholder, plume, exposure, risk communication.
- Explain the workplace tension: Data, uncertainty, exposure, agency role, and next steps need accessible explanation.
- Respond professionally when a stakeholder says: Give a quick yes-or-no answer.
- Draft a usable community-meeting response with facts, caveats, owner, and next step.

Customized scenario

Workplace pressure

Residents ask whether a plume affects drinking water.

Give a quick yes-or-no answer.

Data, uncertainty, exposure, agency role, and next steps need accessible explanation.

Classroom sequence

1. Terminology drill: define each term, then use it in one sentence from the learner's own role.

2. Risk map: identify the stakeholder, the decision, the evidence gap, the operating constraint, and the cost of being wrong.
3. Pushback ladder: move from clarifying question to evidence-based objection to consequence to decision request.
4. Output lab: draft and revise a community-meeting response.

Module 8. Proposal, Scope, and Client Expectations (90 minutes)

Define consulting scope and assumptions clearly.

Learners should be able to

- Use these terms accurately: scope, assumption, deliverable, change order.
- Explain the workplace tension: Scope, assumptions, exclusions, change orders, and deliverables need explicit language.
- Respond professionally when a stakeholder says: Absorb the extra work.
- Draft a usable consulting scope clarification with facts, caveats, owner, and next step.

Customized scenario

Workplace pressure

A client expects unlimited regulatory support under a small budget.

Absorb the extra work.

Scope, assumptions, exclusions, change orders, and deliverables need explicit language.

Classroom sequence

1. Terminology drill: define each term, then use it in one sentence from the learner's own role.
2. Risk map: identify the stakeholder, the decision, the evidence gap, the operating constraint, and the cost of being wrong.
3. Pushback ladder: move from clarifying question to evidence-based objection to consequence to decision request.
4. Output lab: draft and revise a consulting scope clarification.

Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments

Term	Working meaning
Phase I ESA	Working environmental consulting term used in phase i and phase ii site assessments; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
REC	Working environmental consulting term used in phase i and phase ii site assessments; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
Phase II	Working environmental consulting term used in phase i and phase ii site assessments; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
due diligence	Structured review of facts, risks, financials, operations, obligations, or claims before a decision.

Sampling Plans and Data Quality

Term	Working meaning
sampling plan	Working environmental consulting term used in sampling plans and data quality; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
chain of custody	Working environmental consulting term used in sampling plans and data quality; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
detection limit	Working environmental consulting term used in sampling plans and data quality; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
QA/QC	Working environmental consulting term used in sampling plans and data quality; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Permitting and Agency Coordination

Term	Working meaning
permit	Working environmental consulting term used in permitting and agency coordination; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
agency comment	Working environmental consulting term used in permitting and agency coordination; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
public notice	Working environmental consulting term used in permitting and agency coordination; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
modeling	Working environmental consulting term used in permitting and agency coordination; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Remediation Options and Risk

Term	Working meaning
remediation	Working environmental consulting term used in remediation options and risk; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
exposure pathway	Working environmental consulting term used in remediation options and risk; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
cap	Working environmental consulting term used in remediation options and risk; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
long-term monitoring	Working environmental consulting term used in remediation options and risk; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Regulatory Compliance and Audits

Term	Working meaning
compliance audit	Working environmental consulting term used in regulatory compliance and audits; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
corrective action	Action taken to fix a current problem and prevent recurrence.
recordkeeping	Working environmental consulting term used in regulatory compliance and audits; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
inspection	Working environmental consulting term used in regulatory compliance and audits; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Sustainability and ESG Reporting

Term	Working meaning
ESG	Working environmental consulting term used in sustainability and esg reporting; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
Scope 1	Working environmental consulting term used in sustainability and esg reporting; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
Scope 2	Working environmental consulting term used in sustainability and esg reporting; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
Scope 3	Working environmental consulting term used in sustainability and esg reporting; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
carbon neutral	Working environmental consulting term used in sustainability and esg reporting; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Community and Stakeholder Meetings

Term	Working meaning
stakeholder	Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.
plume	Working environmental consulting term used in community and stakeholder meetings; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
exposure	Working environmental consulting term used in community and stakeholder meetings; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
risk communication	Working environmental consulting term used in community and stakeholder meetings; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Proposal, Scope, and Client Expectations

Term	Working meaning
scope	Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.
assumption	Working environmental consulting term used in proposal, scope, and client expectations; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
deliverable	Working environmental consulting term used in proposal, scope, and client expectations; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
change order	Working environmental consulting term used in proposal, scope, and client expectations; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

Situation	Useful language
Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments	Before we commit, I want to confirm Phase I ESA, REC, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If recognized environmental conditions, sampling scope, limitations, and due diligence matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Sampling Plans and Data Quality	Before we commit, I want to confirm sampling plan, chain of custody, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If decision units, detection limits, qa/qc, and regulatory standards must support conclusions., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Permitting and Agency Coordination	Before we commit, I want to confirm permit, agency comment, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If agency discretion, technical support, timelines, and public comments may affect approval., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

Situation	Useful language
Remediation Options and Risk	Before we commit, I want to confirm remediation, exposure pathway, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If exposure pathway, remedy effectiveness, operations disruption, cost, and long-term monitoring matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Regulatory Compliance and Audits	Before we commit, I want to confirm compliance audit, corrective action, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If compliance obligations, corrective action, documentation, and recurrence risk need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Sustainability and ESG Reporting	Before we commit, I want to confirm ESG, Scope 1, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If scope, boundary, methodology, assurance, and claim substantiation are required., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Community and Stakeholder Meetings	Before we commit, I want to confirm stakeholder, plume, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If data, uncertainty, exposure, agency role, and next steps need accessible explanation., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Proposal, Scope, and Client Expectations	Before we commit, I want to confirm scope, assumption, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If scope, assumptions, exclusions, change orders, and deliverables need explicit language., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.
- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.
- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

Assessment and Coaching

Performance rubric

Skill	Developing	Proficient	Strong
Terminology	Recognizes terms but uses them loosely.	Uses field terms accurately in context.	Defines terms, connects them to evidence, and explains decision impact.
Pushback	Disagrees vaguely or avoids disagreement.	Names concern with evidence and next step.	Balances urgency, relationship, risk, owner, and decision rights.
Scenario judgment	Focuses on one stakeholder's preference.	Identifies constraint, risk, and process.	Guides the group toward a documented, realistic decision.
Written output	Writes general summaries.	Produces clear notes with facts and owner.	Creates concise, decision-ready workplace communication.

Source orientation

- EPA and state environmental guidance as applicable.
- Client contracts and project scopes.
- Field sampling, QA/QC, and health-safety plans.
- The learner's own company policies, SOPs, contracts, systems, templates, and approved communication standards.